SESSION 08

# Cover and Table of Contents

Two thresholds a reviewer crosses before the work itself.

Portfolio as Narrative · Cover Typologies, Contents Typologies, and Page Numbering

# Why Today Matters

## What Comes Before the Work

- **The cover** is the first design decision a reviewer meets, and it frames every page that follows.
- **The table of contents** is the reader's first act of navigation. Its design shows them how to move through your work.
- Both should carry the same Red Thread (or, with one project, the same statement) and the same type system as the project pages.

BEFORE THE FIRST PROJECT

- **The cover** the position
- **The contents** the route
- **The numbering** the system

*From Module 14: Cover and Table of Contents.*

# Learning Objectives

After this session, you will be able to:

1. **Read the seven cover typologies** and name the one closest to your project.

2. **Match a cover** to what the project argues and to the type system from Session 07.

3. **Read the six contents typologies** and pick the one that fits the length and structure of your portfolio.

4. **Apply one page numbering system** across the whole file, so the contents page and the project pages agree.

COVER

# Purpose and Tone

Like an opening scene, the cover sets mood and expectation before anyone sees a project.

### Minimal Approach

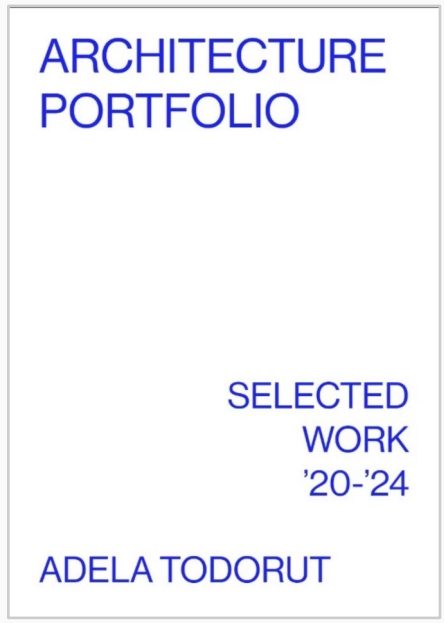
Clean typography and strategic white space convey sophistication and clarity. It suits portfolios built on precision and refined detail.

### Bold Statement

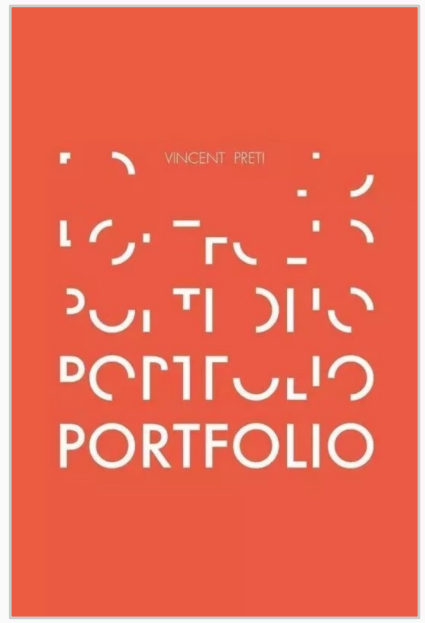
Strong colors, dramatic imagery, or oversized typography suggest confidence and innovation. It suits experimental or cutting-edge work.

### Conceptual Voice

Abstract elements or symbolic graphics hint at a deeper design philosophy. It works for theoretical or research-focused portfolios.




Minimal




Bold statement

*Reference covers from the Crafting the Identity class.*

COVER

# Essential Cover Content

What the cover has to carry, and what it can leave out.

1

### Name and Title

Always include your full name prominently. You can add "Architecture Portfolio" or a graduation year for context, but avoid redundant text that clutters the design.

2

### Visual Elements

Choose between abstracted project details, minimal graphics that hint at your style, or bold typography alone. Each approach communicates a different design sensibility.

3

### Optional Information

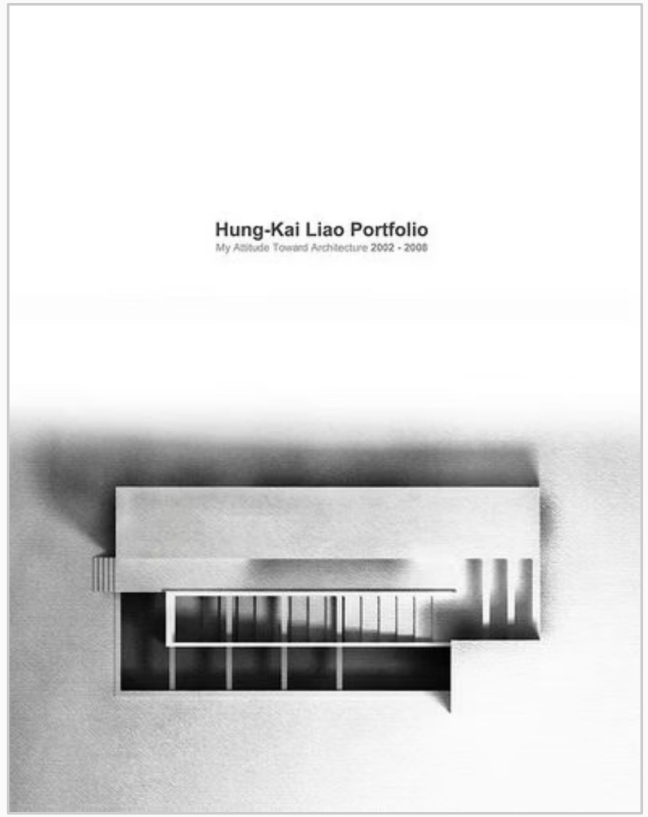
Include dates or institutional affiliations only when they strengthen your positioning. Context matters more than completeness.

COVER

# Choosing the Image

A detail from your best project can be stronger than showing the whole design.

- **Abstract it.** Crop diagrams, model photos, or renderings to create intrigue without revealing everything.
- **Look for** strong geometry, material texture, or an unusual construction detail.
- **Or use type alone.** Sometimes strong typography carries more impact than any image. Let the overall tone of your portfolio decide.




A cropped model image with a small title.

COVER

# Principles and Pitfalls

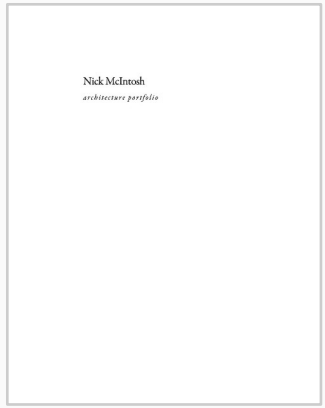
Three things to do and three to avoid.

| PRINCIPLES | PITFALLS |
| --- | --- |
| **Immediate Legibility**<br>Your name must read instantly. Avoid complex backgrounds or low contrast, and test it at thumbnail size. | **Generic Stock Images**<br>Avoid cliché architectural photography or heavy textures that could belong to anyone's portfolio. |
| **Typographic Consistency**<br>Use fonts that match your interior spreads, so the cover feels connected to the work inside. | **Style Disconnect**<br>Do not make the cover so different from your interior pages that it feels disconnected. Coherence builds trust. |
| **Color Psychology**<br>Black and white reads as minimal and timeless. Bold colors suggest energy and innovation. Muted tones suggest subtlety. | **Visual Overload**<br>Resist including every design element you love. A cluttered cover overwhelms the reader. |

COVER

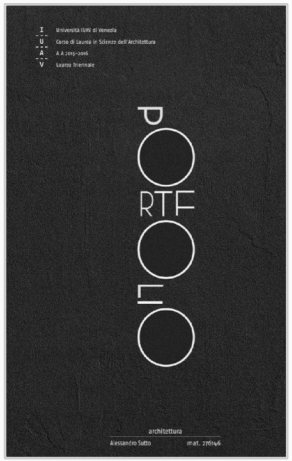
# Seven Cover Typologies

Tone sets the mood. Seven compositional patterns recur across architecture covers to carry it.



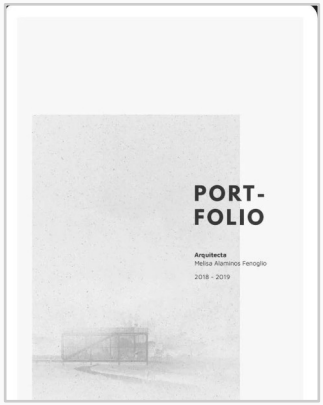

**01 Pure Minimal**

Type only




**02 Dark Ground**

Light type on dark




**03 Hero Image**

One dominant image




**04 Bleed + Type Band**

Image plus type band



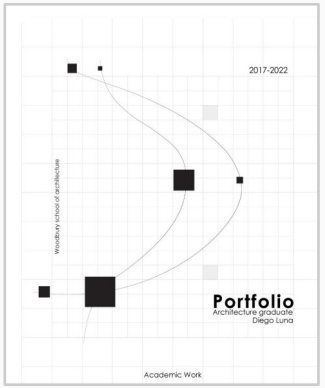

**05 Scattered Collage**

Many small images




**06 Grid / Pattern**

Repeating motif




**07 Abstract Line**

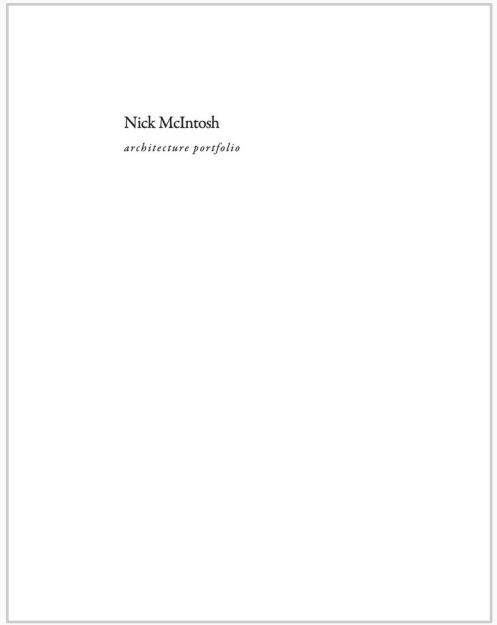
Lines and geometry

*The question is which one fits your narrative, not which one looks best.*

COVER TYPE 01

# Pure Minimal

Maximum white space is the main compositional element, and typography is the only visual content.










**KEY PRINCIPLES**

- Text takes less than 8% of the page. The white space is the design, not leftover space.
- The text cluster sits off center, away from the middle of the page, which creates tension against the empty field.
- Hierarchy lives in a compact cluster of about three lines: shifts in weight, size, and value.
- No imagery and no decoration. The confidence comes from restraint.

**BEST FOR**

Portfolios where the work itself is the entire argument and the cover stays out of the way.

**RISK**

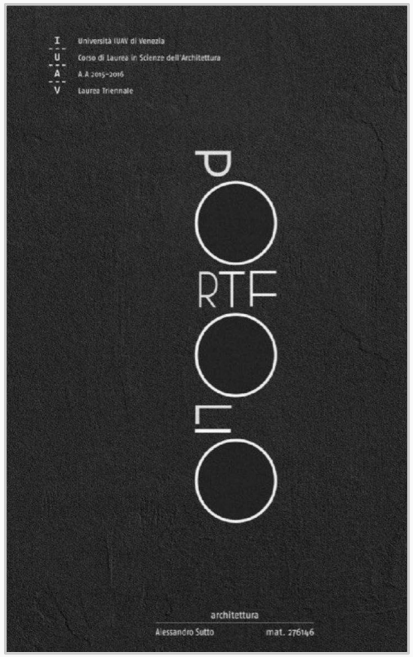
It can read as unfinished if the typography is not precise.

*Reference covers: Lecture 09, Cover Typologies.*

COVER TYPE 02

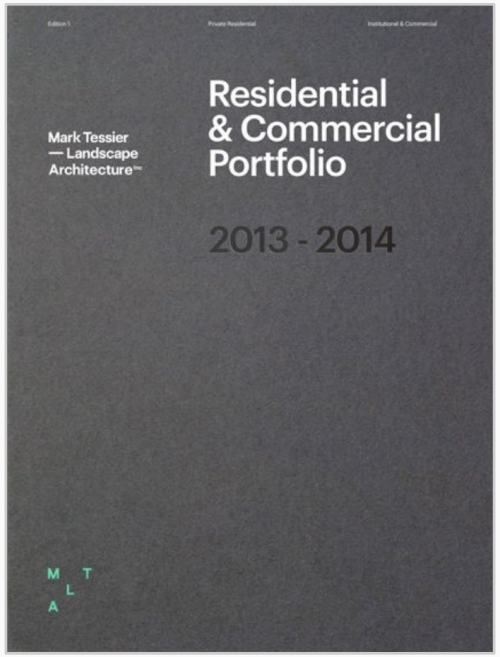
# Dark Ground

Figure and ground invert: a dark surface with light typography.










**KEY PRINCIPLES**

- The dark page becomes the active void and the light type becomes the figure.
- Texture, such as paper grain, concrete, or noise, gives the digital page a material presence.
- Letterforms are often broken apart, rescaled, or mixed with geometric shapes.
- The result is dramatic and atmospheric, and it reads as confident and conceptual.

**BEST FOR**

Portfolios invested in materiality, craft, or atmosphere.

**RISK**

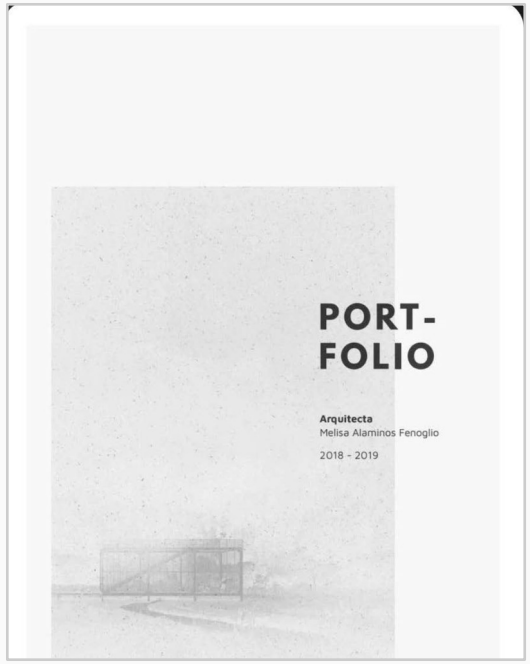
Dark backgrounds reproduce inconsistently across screens and printers.

*Reference covers: Lecture 09, Cover Typologies.*

COVER TYPE 03

# Hero Image

Three vertical bands with one dominant image as the anchor.







KEY PRINCIPLES

- Header about 17%, image about 58%, footer about 25%. The reading order is title, image, author.
- One image takes 55 to 65% of the page and carries the portfolio's identity.
- Text stays small and peripheral, anchoring the corners without competing with the image.
- Choose the image carefully. It has to represent your strongest or most characteristic project.

BEST FOR

A single project image strong enough to represent the entire portfolio.

RISK

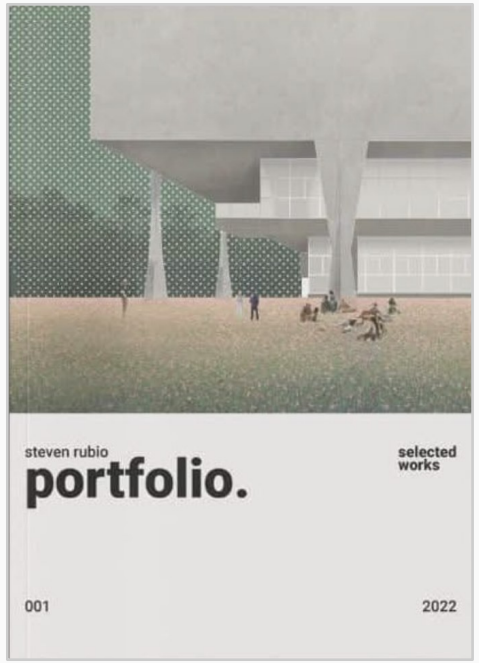
The image must earn the position. A weak hero weakens everything that follows.

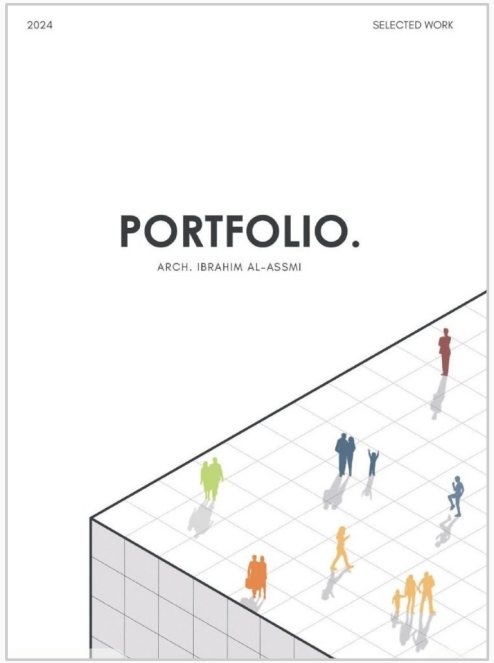
*Reference covers: Lecture 09, Cover Typologies.*

COVER TYPE 04

# Bleed Image + Type Band

Two zones: an image that bleeds to the edges and a distinct band of type.




**KEY PRINCIPLES**

- Image zone 60 to 70%, type band 30 to 40%.
- The hard dividing edge between the zones creates the main tension. Never use a gradient or fade.
- The image bleeds to the page edges, which implies it continues beyond the frame.
- The band uses a bold title and corner anchors, such as an issue number or date, to balance the image.

**BEST FOR**

Portfolios that lead with visual impact.

**RISK**

The band must be deliberate: too thin reads as a mistake, too thick obscures the image.

*Reference covers: Lecture 09, Cover Typologies.*

COVER TYPE 05

# Scattered Collage

Many images arranged at irregular spacing and variable scale.




KEY PRINCIPLES

- Thumbnails spread across the whole field, with no single focal point.
- Variable scale creates rhythm and an implied hierarchy among projects without labels.
- Irregular spacing should feel curated. Proximity implies a relationship.
- The title floats among the images as one element, not in a separate type zone.

BEST FOR

Portfolios spanning many project types or scales.

RISK

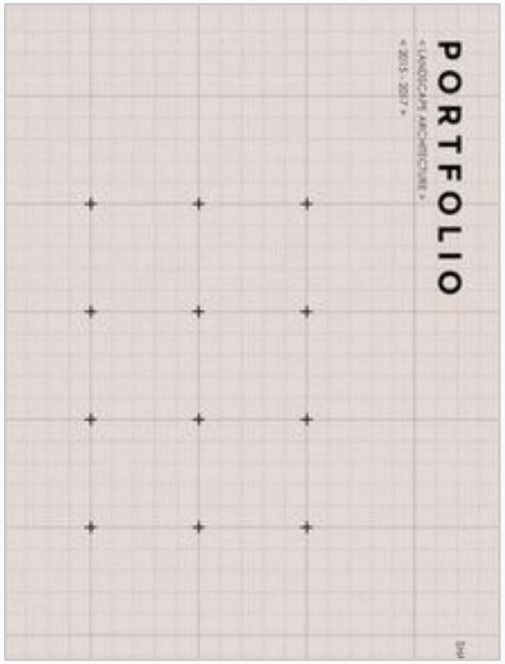
Without a clear hierarchy, a collage reads as disorganized. One image should still dominate.

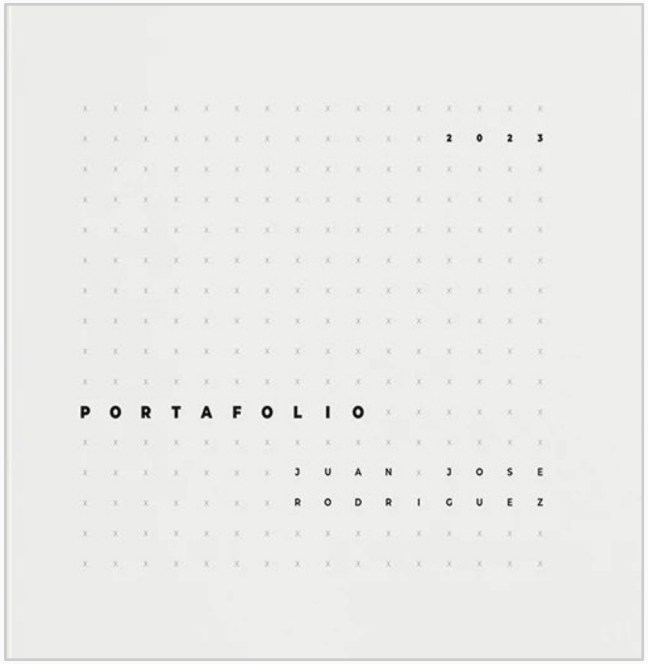
*Reference covers: Lecture 09, Cover Typologies.*

COVER TYPE 06

# Grid / Pattern System

A repeating geometric motif as the visual identity.




KEY PRINCIPLES

- One small unit, such as a cross, dot, plus mark, or tick, repeats at equal intervals across the field.
- Letter-spacing in the title is calibrated to the grid interval, so type and pattern share one logic.
- Regularity suggests systematic thinking and rigor: order over expression.
- The pattern replaces imagery and often references drafting conventions.

BEST FOR

Portfolios with a strong structural or computational thread.

RISK

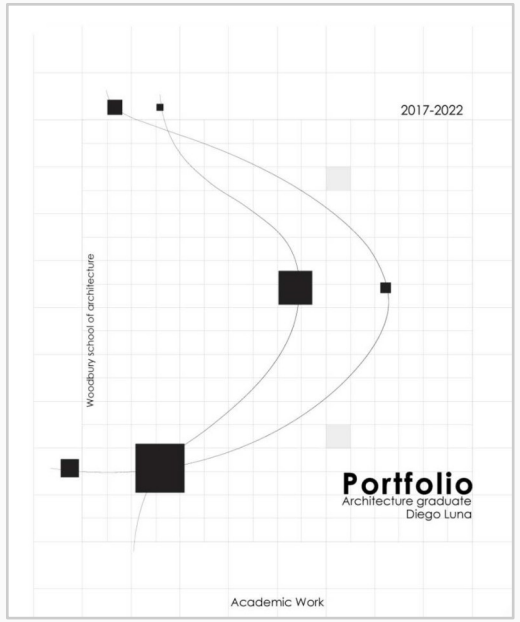
The pattern can overwhelm the title if the type lacks contrast.

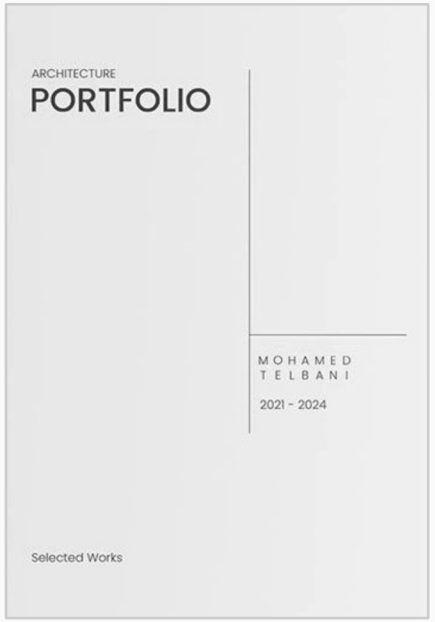
*Reference covers: Lecture 09, Cover Typologies.*

COVER TYPE 07

# Abstract Line

Freeform curves, intersecting lines, and geometric primitives.







**KEY PRINCIPLES**

- Two or three geometric elements, such as arcs and lines, with a clear stroke weight hierarchy.
- Intersections work as visual anchors, often marked with a dot or a date.
- The text sits in the quiet zone, the negative space the geometry leaves.
- Freeform and deliberate, not systematic. Every element is a considered decision.

**BEST FOR**

Portfolios where the design position is formal or experimental.

**RISK**

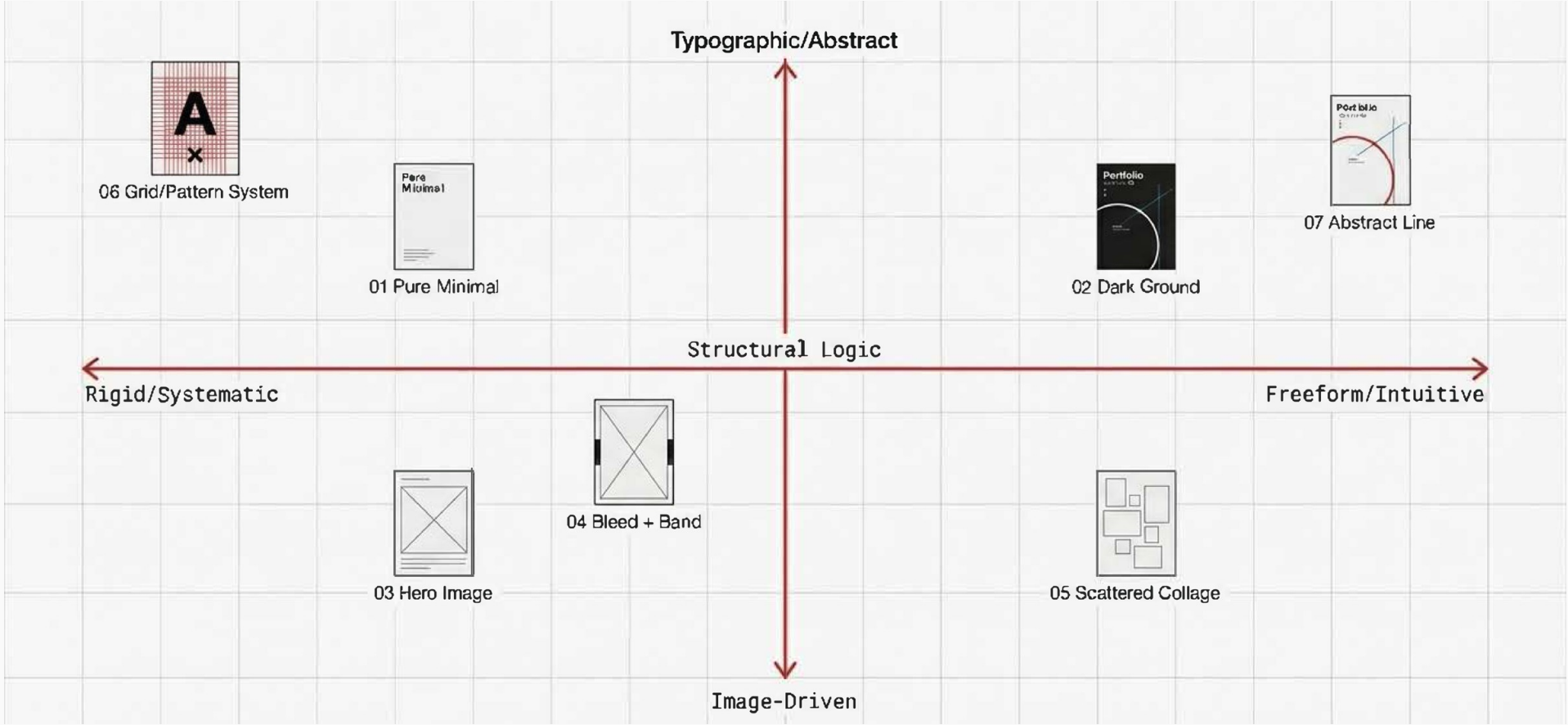
Abstraction without a connection to the work reads as decoration.

*Reference covers: Lecture 09, Cover Typologies.*

COVER

# Where the Seven Types Sit

Rigid or freeform, typographic or image-driven. Figure from Lecture 09.



COVER

# Choosing Your Cover

Four questions to put to any cover you sketch.

### What first impression do I want to create?

Start from what the project argues. Grads: your Red Thread. Undergrads: your project statement. Choose the type whose mood fits it.

### Does my strongest image represent the whole?

If it does, a hero image or a bleed cover can work. If it does not, consider type, a pattern, or a collage.

### Who is my audience?

A reviewer, an employer, and a jury read a cover differently. Decide who it is for before you choose.

### Does the cover continue into the interior?

It should feel like page one of the same portfolio: the same type system from Session 07 and the same grid.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

# What the Contents Page Does

More than a project list, it is the roadmap of your portfolio.

### Structure Overview

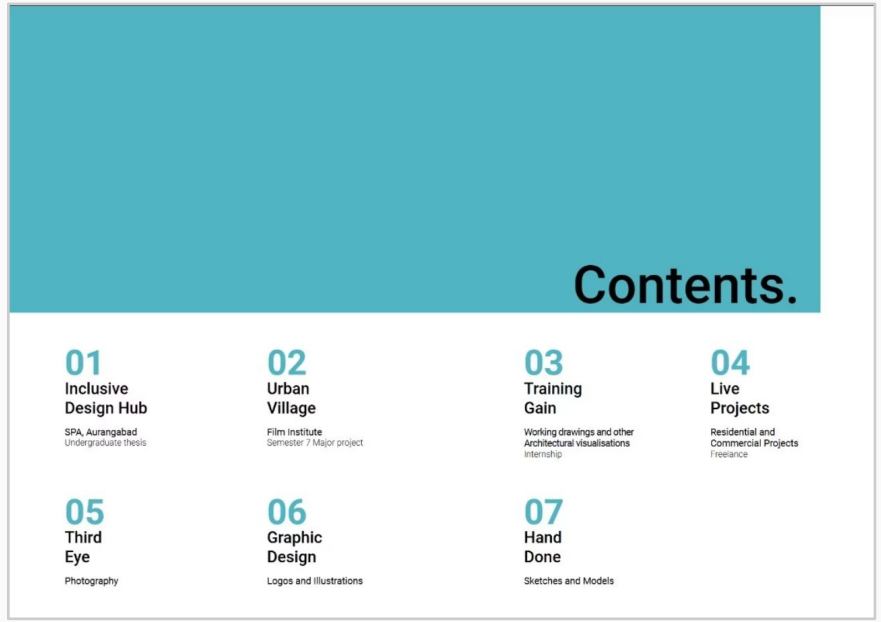
Gives an immediate sense of the scope and organization of your work, so a reviewer grasps its breadth at a glance.

### Navigation Tool

Essential for longer portfolios, especially in digital formats. It lets a reviewer jump to specific projects during an interview or review.

### Professionalism Signal

A well-designed contents page shows attention to detail and organizational thinking.




**A contents page with a color field and numbered entries.**

*It is not filler between cover and content. Its design teaches the reviewer how to move through your work.*

TABLE OF CONTENTS

# What Goes on the Page

Titles, page numbers, and supporting details.

### Project Titles

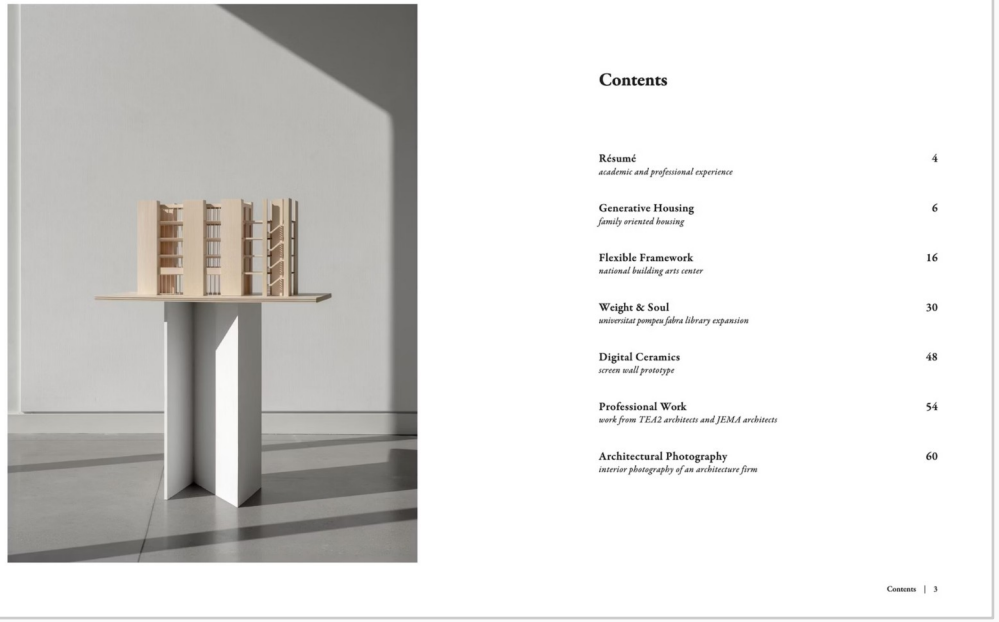
Replace generic names like "Studio Project 1" with conceptual titles, such as "Framing Light," "Urban Interlace," or "Threshold Dynamics." Keep them short, reflect design concepts rather than building types, and consider poetic or metaphorical language.

### Page Numbers

Include clear page references, especially in printed or PDF portfolios. For longer projects, consider both starting pages and page ranges.

### Supporting Details

Add year, studio name, or instructor sparingly for academic work. Include location for built projects. Keep the hierarchy clear: titles stay primary.




Case Study 02's contents page: a short list beside one model photograph.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

# Design Considerations

The contents page has to look like the rest of the portfolio.

### Visual Consistency

Your contents typography and grid must connect with the rest of the portfolio. Inconsistency here looks careless.

### Hierarchy Management

Project titles should dominate the spread, with supporting information clearly secondary. Use size, weight, and spacing to guide the eye.

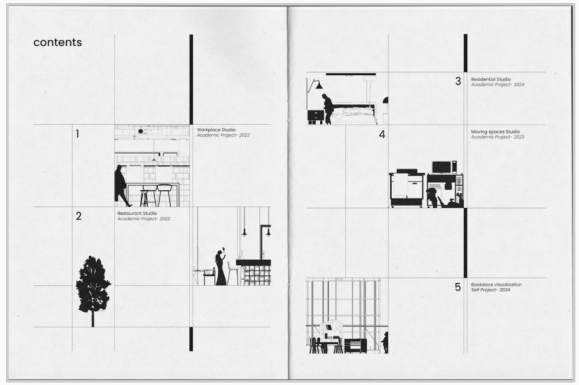
### White Space Strategy

Generous spacing prevents overcrowding and shows your command of layout. White space is active, not empty.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

# Six Contents Typologies

Six contents typologies recur across architecture and design portfolios. Reference spreads from Lecture 10.




**01 Illustrated Section Grid**



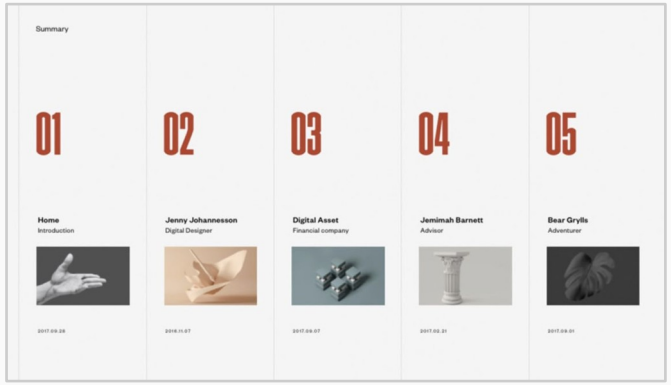

**02 Multi-Column Text Index**




**03 Thumbnail Gallery Row**




**04 Literary Chapter Index**




**05 Bold Number Column Cards**

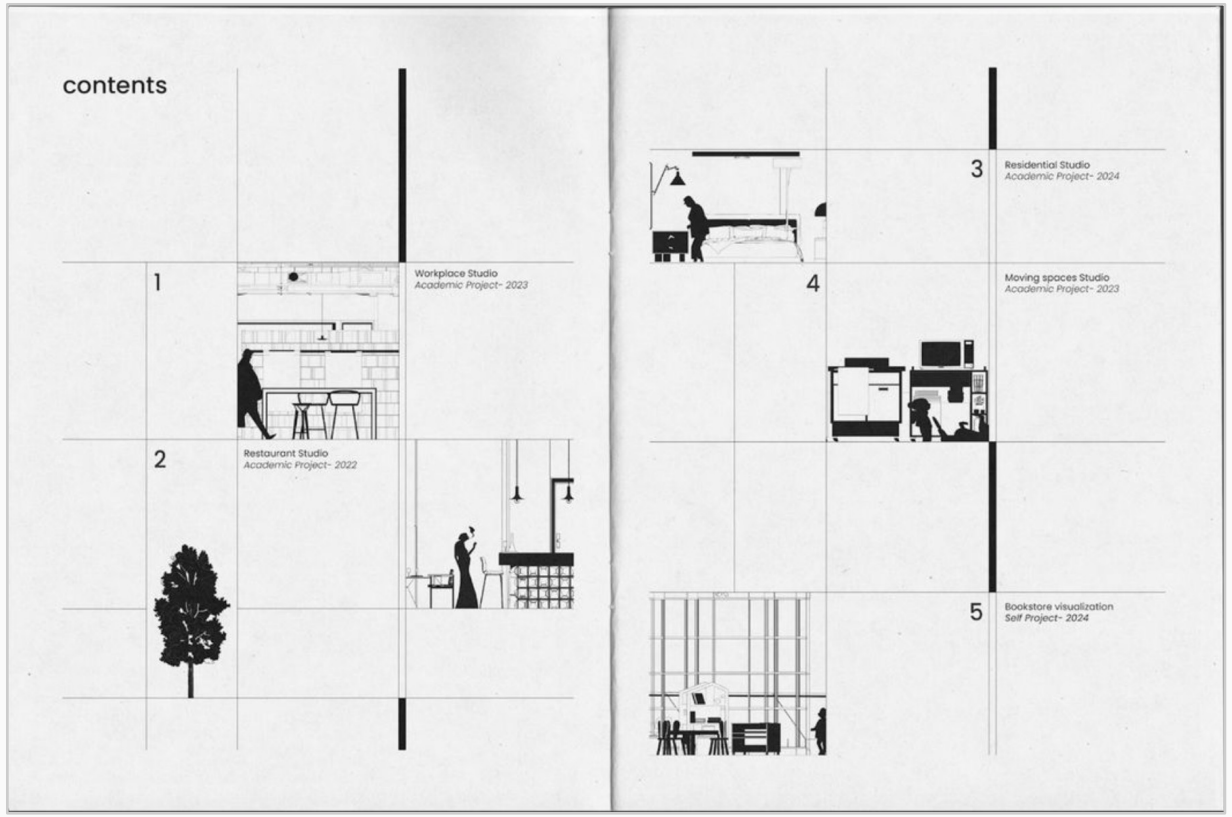


**06 Narrative + List Hybrid**

CONTENTS TYPE 01

# Illustrated Section Grid

Architectural vignettes in a modular grid, separated by bold vertical dividers.




MODULAR GRID · IMAGE-LED · TWO-PAGE SPREAD · VERTICAL DIVIDERS

### STRUCTURE

A two-page spread divided into equal columns by thick black rules. Each column has a black and white architectural silhouette at the top with project details stacked below.

### HIERARCHY

Oversized section numbers anchor each column. Project title, institution, and page number follow in descending weight.

### BEST FOR

Architecture-focused portfolios with 4 to 8 major projects that can be represented by iconic silhouettes or section drawings.

CONTENTS TYPE 02

# Multi-Column Text Index

A purely typographic, information-dense index modeled on editorial design.




TEXT ONLY · MULTI-COLUMN · EDITORIAL · INFORMATION DENSE

### STRUCTURE

Three columns per page, with entries in numbered sequence. Each entry cascades through category, institution, bold project title, description, collaborators, and page number.

### HIERARCHY

Typographic weight and size only: bold titles, regular descriptions, light credits. No decoration.

### BEST FOR

Portfolios with many projects (10 or more) or extensive details for each entry, especially academic or research-heavy work.

CONTENTS TYPE 03

# Thumbnail Gallery Row

A single row of equally sized thumbnails, with plenty of white space.




HORIZONTAL STRIP · IMAGE-LED · WHITE SPACE · MINIMAL TEXT

STRUCTURE

One horizontal row of uniformly sized project images across the page width. Page numbers and bold project titles sit directly beneath each thumbnail.

HIERARCHY

Images are the entry point. Text is minimal: project name and location.

BEST FOR

Portfolios with 5 to 7 visually distinct projects, where a single image can represent each body of work.

CONTENTS TYPE 04

# Literary Chapter Index

Oversized serif page numbers and letter-spaced headings, a book-design approach.




SERIF TYPE · LARGE NUMERALS · BOOK DESIGN · LETTERSPACING

### STRUCTURE

Large serif page numbers (11, 91, 155) at the top of each entry, then letter-spaced section headings in capitals, then italic names and titles.

### HIERARCHY

The numeral is the anchor, both a navigation aid and a compositional element. Letter-spacing gives weight without bold.

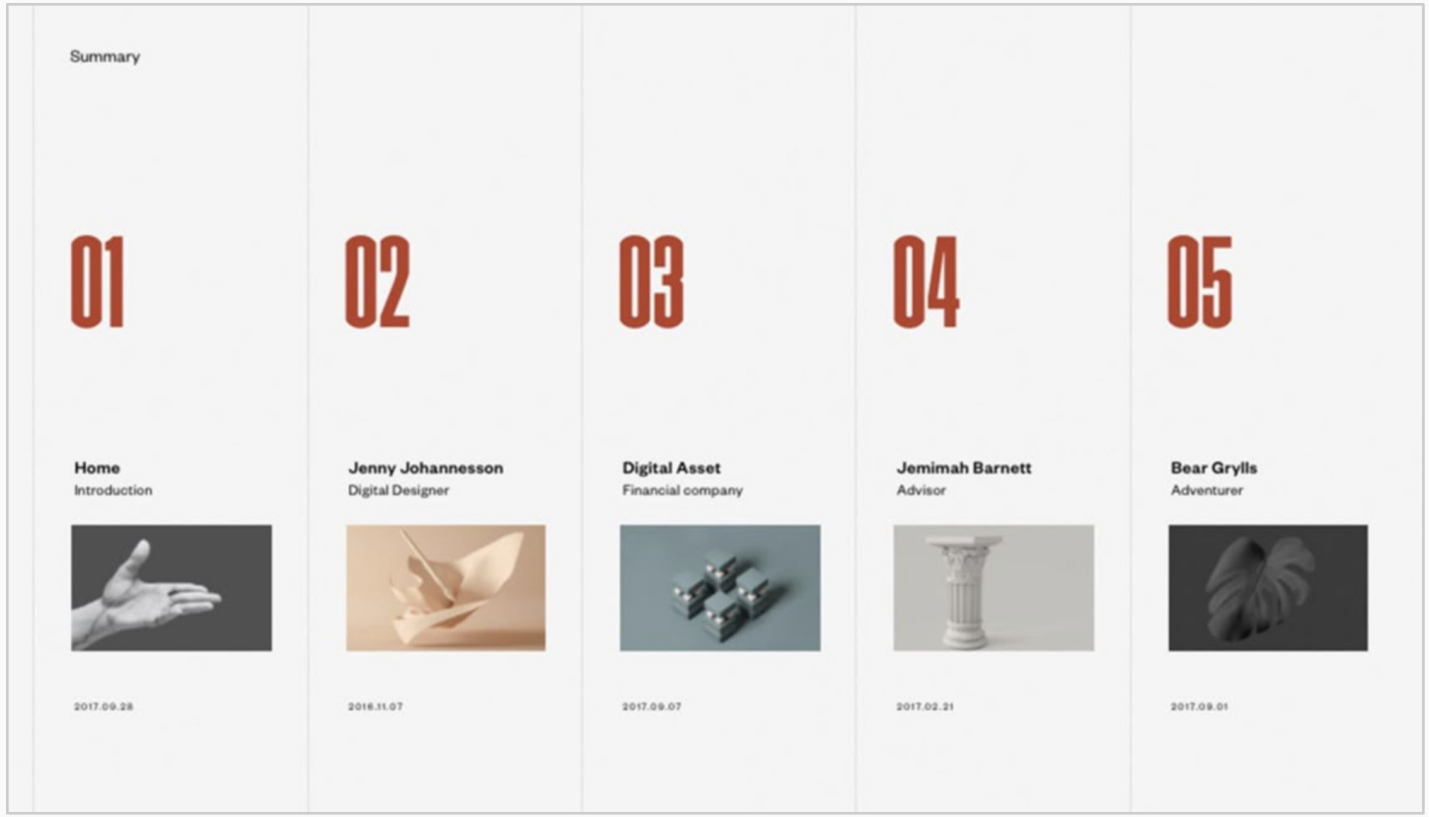
### BEST FOR

Portfolios organized as monographs, thematic collections, or work with significant written or theoretical components.

CONTENTS TYPE 05

# Bold Number Column Cards

Vertical columns with oversized colored numbers, thumbnails, and details.




COLUMN CARDS · ACCENT COLOR · MAGAZINE STYLE · VERTICAL RULES

### STRUCTURE

Vertical columns divided by thin rules. Each column is a card with an oversized colored number (01 to 05), bold name, role, thumbnail, and date.

### HIERARCHY

The large number dominates, then the bold title, then lighter details. The thumbnail adds variety inside a strict grid.

### BEST FOR

A small, curated set of projects (3 to 6), especially those that emphasize people, roles, or process alongside final work.

CONTENTS TYPE 06

# Narrative + List Hybrid

A two-page spread pairing a statement or essay page with a contents list.




**TWO-PAGE SPREAD · NARRATIVE · ESSAY + LIST · ACCENT HEADER**

### STRUCTURE

The left page has an essay with an architectural drawing. The right page is a contents list with bold titles, subtitles, and right-aligned page numbers under an accent header.

### HIERARCHY

The essay gives the conceptual framing (why). The list gives navigation (where). The accent header bridges the two.

### BEST FOR

Portfolios that emphasize process, narrative, or a conceptual framework, especially thesis work with a strong design statement.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

# Contents Typology Matrix

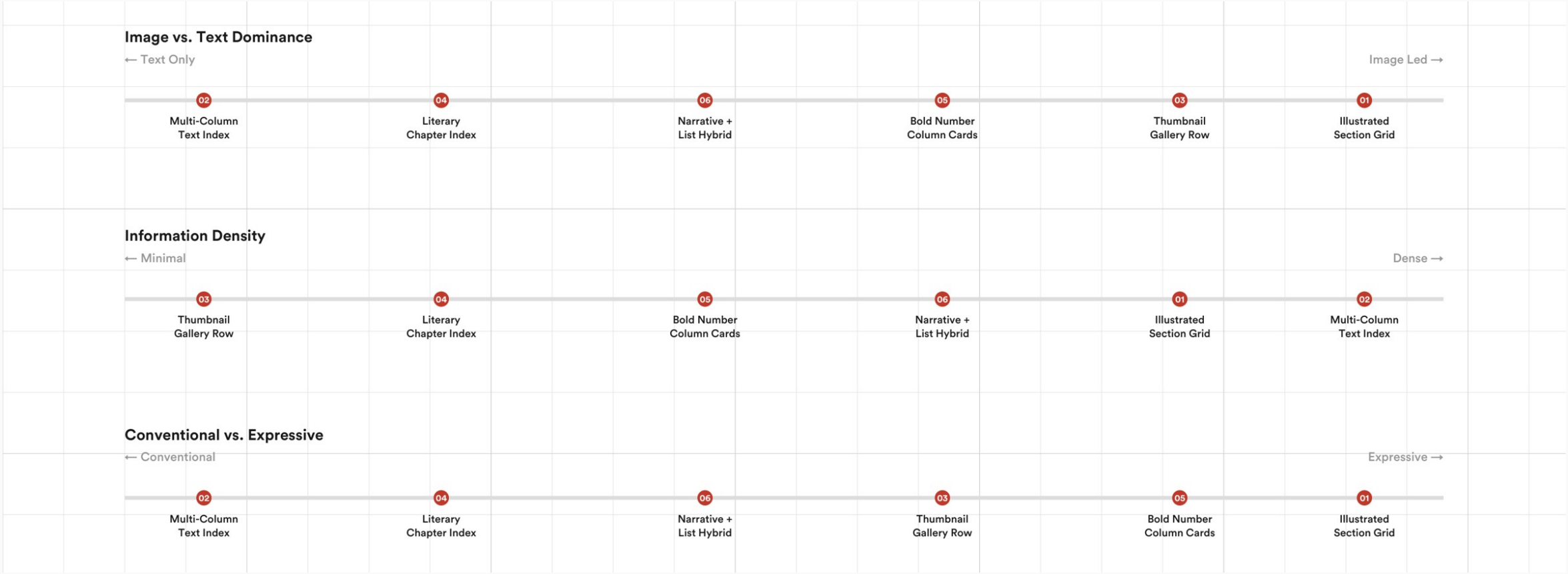
Structure and best use, side by side.

| Typology | Approach | Best for |
|---|---|---|
| **01 Illustrated Section Grid** | Modular grid with architectural vignettes as the main navigation | 4 to 8 projects with strong visual identities |
| **02 Multi-Column Text Index** | Dense typographic layout with no images | 10 or more projects; academic or research contexts |
| **03 Thumbnail Gallery Row** | One image strip with maximum white space | 5 to 7 visually distinct projects; clean aesthetic |
| **04 Literary Chapter Index** | Large serif numerals and letter-spaced headings | Thematic, essay-driven, or theoretical work |
| **05 Bold Number Column Cards** | Vertical cards with oversized accent numbers and thumbnails | 3 to 6 curated projects; profile-driven |
| **06 Narrative + List Hybrid** | Essay page plus contents list | Thesis portfolios with a strong design narrative |

TABLE OF CONTENTS

# Where the Six Types Sit

Image or text, minimal or dense, conventional or expressive. Figure from Lecture 10.



SYSTEM

# One Numbering System

The format matters less than the commitment to one system.

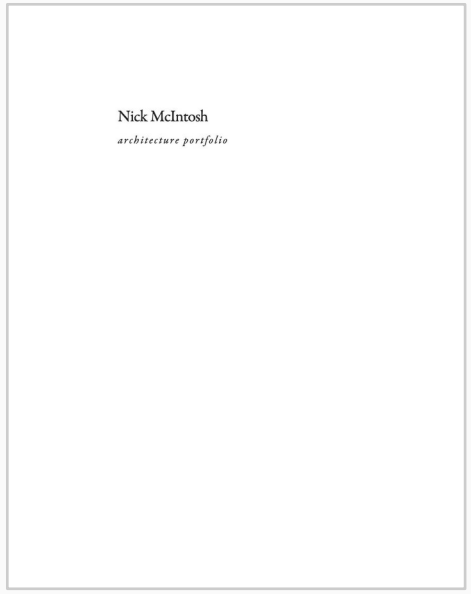
| Decision | Options |
| --- | --- |
| **Where numbering starts** | Academic portfolios number from the cover onward. Professional portfolios begin numbering after the front matter. |
| **How front matter is numbered** | Roman numerals mark introductory pages. Arabic numerals mark project pages. |
| **In InDesign** | Put the page number marker on your parent pages (Type > Insert Special Character > Markers > Current Page Number). Set the start number and roman style under Layout > Numbering & Section Options. |

Pick one system and apply it without exception. Inconsistent numbering makes a portfolio look assembled in haste, whatever the quality of the work inside.

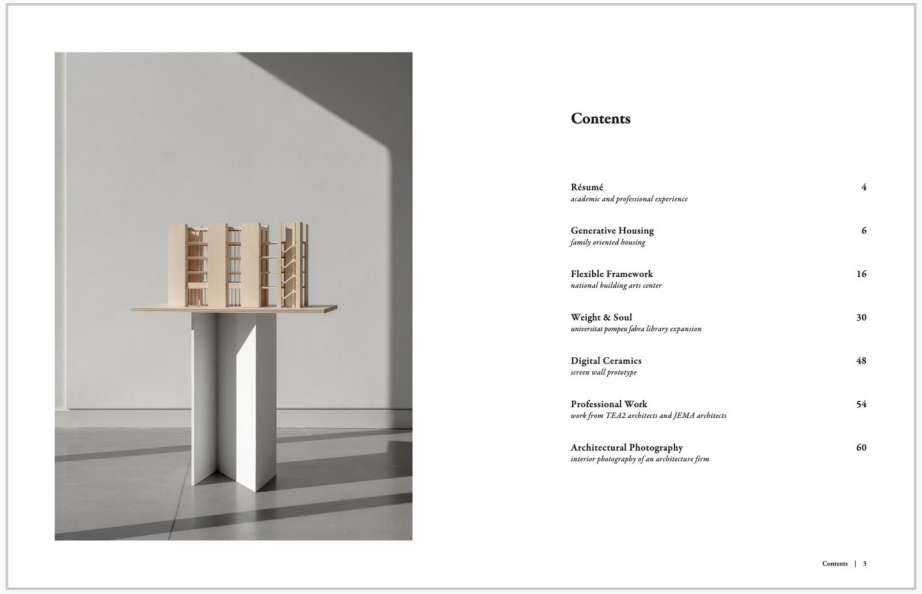
EXAMPLE

# One System from Cover to Project

Case Study 02: the cover, the contents page, and a project title page share one type system.




**Cover**




**Contents**




**Project title page**

The contents page lists Generative Housing on page 6 and Flexible Framework on page 16, and the project title pages open on those pages. All three pages are set in serif type with a restrained hierarchy.

EXAMPLE

# One System Across Projects

Case Study 02: the same title-page format for both projects.



Generative Housing

*Mixed Use, Multi-Family Housing*
*St. Louis, Missouri*

Generative housing, a multi-family, mixed use housing project occupies one city block of Downtown West, St. Louis, and aims to counter contemporary multi-family development trends being built across the city of St. Louis. Trends that emphasize private amenities over public space, parking access over retail access, and maximizing unit counts over maximizing livability. These trends lead to housing projects that become isolated enclaves "accessible only by car" within the city and give little back to the neighborhoods where they are placed.

The Generative Housing proposal attempts to counter these issues through a number of architectural strategies. First, the project is designed as a thin ribbon of housing that meanders through the site in strategic ways to generate public plaza spaces. Each plaza serves a specific purpose, whether it be for organized sport, playground space, or gardening space. Second, the project provides units that are larger than the average unit available in St. Louis. The average unit size in the proposal is approximately 1800 square feet, which is the size of a typical single-family home in the city. Apartments are designed for families and growth versus for young professionals and quick profits. Finally, the housing buries parking and limits the number of parking spots in an effort to encourage diverse transportation modalities. Locating parking underground opens up the ground floor for retail and amenity spaces to invite residents of the building and city inside.

*Professors: Adrian Luchini*
*Washington University in St. Louis*
*Fall 2022*

6 | Nick McIntosh

Generative Housing | 7

**Generative Housing**



Flexible Framework

*National Building Arts Center*
*St. Louis, Missouri*

The National Building Art Center, as it currently stands, is an archive for architectural and building trades artifacts and literature that have been acquired throughout the United States. Many of the artifacts within the collection originate from the city of St. Louis and relate to the city's industrial past. A past that made heavy use of masonry and cast iron techniques that are beginning to fade in modern construction. Flexible Framework is a building arts center that contains exhibition, archive, education, and maker space that serves the National Building Arts Center of St. Louis, Missouri.

Tasked with housing the diverse programmatic requirements of the Building Arts Center, the design of the new structure is composed of a timber framework capable of hosting a multitude of functions. The stable, structural framework acts as a matrix upon which elements can be attached to; gantry cranes, curtains, shelving systems, displays, operable doors, and more are able to fit within the framework and be applied in specific ways to address specific needs. Long spans, operability, concrete, heavy timber, and ceramics–spatial and material strategies that relate to St. Louis's industrial architecture–are employed in unique ways that are both cognizant of the industry that created St. Louis and anticipant of a new age of production.

*Professor: Kelley Van Dyck Murphy*
*Washington University in St. Louis*
*Spring 2021*

16 | Nick McIntosh

Flexible Framework | 17

**Flexible Framework**

The same typographic system, image placement, and text structure on both. A reviewer who meets the second divider already knows where to find the statement, the credits, and the image.

DISCUSSION

# Your Cover and Contents

Talk these through in your cohort breakout.

**UNDERGRAD (44611)**

Does your cover need to admit you're a student, or is it fine that it doesn't? What is the minimum viable complete portfolio for someone entering the field for the first time?

**GRAD (56995)**

Does your cover read as a working designer's, not a student's? Is this ready to send to an employer tomorrow? If not, name the single blocking issue.

After class: draft your cover and table of contents in your project file, ready to show in the review sessions.